

LITTLE SPROUT STORIES

Marcus & Sophie Visit the Barbershop

A story about feeling scared — and watching a friend go first



Today was a day of very firsts: Sophie’s very first haircut, ever in her whole life. Marcus came along, because Marcus had had lots of haircuts, and he already knew what to expect — the spinning chair, the big mirror, and the kind man who ran the shop on the corner.

Sophie gets a haircut.



The bell over the door jingled, and Mr. Smith looked up with a grin that crinkled his whole face. “Well, hello!” he said. “Marcus, my old friend — and you must be Sophie. I’ve been saving you the best seat in the shop.” From somewhere across the room came a soft, faraway sound: bzzzzz.

Mr. Smith says hello.



“Before my first customer,” said Mr. Smith, “I get everything clean and ready.” He swept the floor until it shone, washed his combs and brushes, oiled his clippers with two careful drops, and folded a stack of fresh, fluffy towels. “A barber’s first job isn’t cutting hair. It’s keeping every tool clean and safe — because clean tools protect everybody who sits in my chair.”

Mr. Smith cleans his tools every day.



Marcus pointed at everything, proud as a tour guide. “Those are the clippers — they trim short, short hair. Those are the scissors — snip, snip — for longer hair. That’s the cape, so the itchy bits don’t fall on your clothes. And that—” he pointed at the great chair, “—is the chair that spins.” Sophie looked at the shining row of tools. “There are so many,” she said.

Mr. Smith has clippers and scissors.



On a shelf sat a row of practice heads, each with a different tangle of hair. “Even barbers practice,” Mr. Smith explained. “We rehearse new styles on pretend heads first, and we practice keeping our hands steady as stones. Nobody’s real hair is for practicing on — that wouldn’t be fair at all.”

Barbers practice to get better.



All morning, the shop was full of neighbors: a grandfather getting his Sunday trim, a teenager asking for something new and brave, a father and a baby getting matching haircuts. Everybody chatted, everybody laughed, and everybody walked out standing a little taller. “A barber doesn’t just know hair,” said Mr. Smith. “A barber knows the whole neighborhood — and the neighborhood knows him.”

The barbershop is for everyone.



“Here’s my most important rule,” Mr. Smith told Sophie, holding up one finger. “I always explain before I do, and I always ask before I start. May I put the cape on? May I spray a little water? Nothing in my shop is a surprise.” He nodded at the spray bottle. “And at home, you can help too: washing hair keeps it healthy, and gentle brushing — never yanking — keeps the tangles away.”

Mr. Smith always asks first.



Then Mr. Smith picked up the clippers to trim a fuzzy edge nearby — and close up, the sound wasn't soft and faraway anymore. BZZZZZ, buzzed the clippers, loud as a whole hive of bees. Sophie froze in her seat. "That buzzing sound," she whispered, clutching the arms of her chair, "is scary."

Sophie feels bad.

How does Sophie feel?

- ◯ Excited
- ◯ Scared
- ◯ Sleepy



Marcus looked at Sophie’s wide eyes, and he remembered — really remembered — feeling exactly that way once too, in this very chair. He hopped up. “Sophie,” he said, “want me to go first, so you can watch? Then you’ll know every single thing that’s going to happen. No surprises.”

Marcus goes first.



So Sophie watched, closely, as Marcus climbed up and sat calmly through his trim — cape, spray, snip-snip, and even a ticklish part near his ears that made him giggle into his shoulders. Then Mr. Smith did something kind: he put the clippers, turned safely OFF, right into Sophie's hands. They were quiet. They were still. They weren't scary at all. "Oh," said Sophie. "Oh! They're just… clippers."

Sophie holds the tool.

What helped Sophie feel brave?

- ◯ Ignoring the clippers
- ◯ Watching a friend go first
- ◯ Running away



“You know my favorite part of this job?” Mr. Smith asked, dusting Marcus off with the soft brush. “It isn’t the scissors, and it isn’t the spinning chair. It’s watching somebody walk out of my shop feeling fresh and new and proud — a little taller than when they walked in. And a first haircut?” He smiled at Sophie. “A first haircut is a big day. I get to be part of it.”

Mr. Smith helps people feel fresh and new.



Sophie climbed into the chair — brave, ready, and all by herself. Cape on (he asked first). A little spray (he asked first). Snip-snip, buzz-buzz, and before she knew it, it was finished. Mr. Smith spun the chair toward the big mirror, and Sophie gasped at the girl smiling back: same Sophie, brand-new hair. “I did it,” she said. “I really, really did it.”

Sophie sees her new haircut.



■ Barbershop Explorer

Great reading!

For Grown-Ups

Feeling/skill: Fear of the unknown eases when a trusted peer goes first.

Ask your child: Has a friend ever helped you feel brave about something new?

Try this: Let an older sibling or friend “go first” for a new experience this week.

Words to grow on: jingled, steady, rehearse, neighborhood, gentle, brave, expect, finished. Point at the tools as you name them — clippers, scissors, comb, cape, spray bottle.

The bigger picture: Barbers do much more than cut hair — they clean and oil their tools before every customer so germs never spread, practice new styles on mannequin heads instead of real people, explain each step and ask permission before they start, teach families how to care for hair at home, and run a shop where the whole neighborhood gathers and everyone leaves feeling fresh and confident.

Standards: L.K.1.b, L.K.5.b

The End — thanks for reading!